

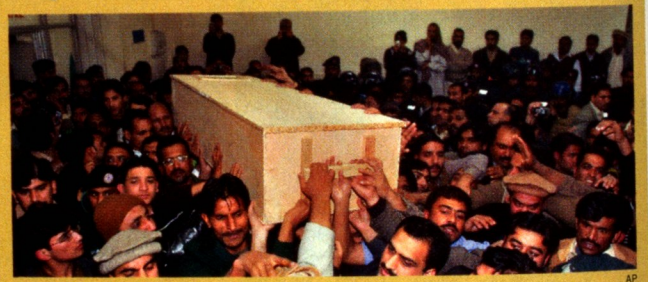
HOW DID BHUTTO DIE?

In the absence of a postmortem, questions abound over how Bhutto met her brutal end

- 1 Initial reports said Bhutto fell to bullets at a meeting in Rawalpindi before a suicide bomber blew himself up next to her bullet-proof vehicle.
- 2 The Pakistan Government claimed that instead of assassin's bullets it was the shock of the blast caused by the suicide bomber that resulted in a grievous fracture to Bhutto's skull when her head struck the lever of the sunroof of the SUV.



- 3 The Government's theory was exposed when an amateur video recording showed a young man in dark glasses standing near her SUV and firing bullets at Bhutto, after which she slumped into the SUV, apparently wounded, and then the blast occurred.



supporters through the sunroof was a fatal mistake on Bhutto's and her security personnel's part. Had she remained inside the car, she would have survived. It is entirely possible that the lapses of security and forensic procedures were simply related to the usual inefficiency of governmental agencies.

The problem is that popular perception is unwilling to concede any simple explanation. The Government has laid the blame squarely on Baitullah Mehsud, a fugitive militant from the tribal areas, whom it blames for most of the suicide attacks in Pakistan. Mehsud heads the Pakistani Taliban Council and has allegedly tied up with Al Qaeda. The Government claims to have intercepted a telephone call wherein he is congratulating one of his men for the operation. But aside

from the fact that he has apparently denied complicity, for most Pakistanis the assassination is nothing less than a deep-rooted conspiracy hatched by Musharraf himself and carried out by his intelligence agencies.

The truth about who exactly was behind Bhutto's murder may never be discovered or believed—despite Musharraf belatedly agreeing to bring in a team from Scotland Yard to probe the incident—but it must be said that if anyone has suffered as a consequence of it after Bhutto herself and her party, it is Musharraf. Not only has it turned popular sentiment even more resolutely against him, it has given his political opponents a new vigour and urgency and shattered his support in much of the West. Statements by US presidential front-runners, such as

Hillary Clinton, who expressed no confidence in Musharraf, indicate that given half an alternative, they would readily withdraw American backing for him. Even the president could not have predicted that, having taken off his uniform only on November 15, he would become dispensable so quickly.

Bhutto's removal from the country's political scene also robs Musharraf of potentially the most important ally in the war against extremism. No other politician had the kind of popular support she commanded. Given the US pressure, it seemed likely she would have allied herself with Musharraf had her party won the elections. This would have certainly bolstered his sagging credibility. The only other leader with significant popular support, Sharif, has continued to take a hard line against the president primarily because of his own history with the former top general. In fact, even as he reversed his decision to boycott the polls, Sharif called on Musharraf to "step down



Charged with a cover-up, Musharraf called Scotland Yard to investigate Bhutto's death